UPSC Civil Services Mains — Anthropology Optional Paper I

Foundations of Anthropology

Syllabus outline for focused preparation

1.1 Meaning, Scope and Development of Anthropology

• Meaning, scope and development of Anthropology.

• Relationships with other disciplines: Social Sciences, behavioural Sciences, Life Sciences, Medical Sciences, Earth Sciences and Humanities.

• Main branches of Anthropology, their scope and relevance: (a) Social-cultural Anthropology; (b) Biological Anthropology; (c) Archaeological Anthropology; (d) Linguistic Anthropology.

• Emergence of Anthropology as a discipline; relationship with other disciplines and major branches of Anthropology.

1.2.1 Culture and Society

• Concept of culture; society; relationship between culture and society; society and culture in the context of India.

1.2.2 Marriage

• Definition and universality; laws of marriage (endogamy, exogamy, hypergamy, hypogamy, incest taboo); forms of marriage (monogamy, polygamy, polyandry, group marriage); functions of marriage; marriage regulations (preferential, prescriptive and proscriptive); marriage payments (bride price, dowry, bride wealth).

1.2.3 Family

• Definition and universality; family, household and domestic groups; functions of family; structure and forms of family; family and marriage; family, kinship and descent; contemporary changes in family.

1.2.4 Kinship

• Descent, alliance and residence; types of kinship terminologies; descent groups; kinship systems in India.

1.3.1 Economic Anthropology

• Meaning, scope and relevance of economic anthropology; formalist and substantivist debate; principles governing production, distribution and exchange (reciprocity, redistribution and market), in societies with simple technology and in industrial societies.

1.3.2 Political Anthropology

• Meaning, scope and relevance of political anthropology; differences between state and stateless political systems; types of political organization; concepts of power, authority and legitimacy; social control; law and justice in simple societies.

1.3.3 Religion

• Anthropological approaches to the study of religion (animism, animatism, fetishism, naturism and monotheism); religious specialists (priest, shaman, medicine man, sorcerer and witch).

1.3.4 Anthropological Theories

• Classical evolutionism (Tylor, Morgan and Frazer); historical particularism (Boas); diffusionism (British, German and American); functionalism (Malinowski); structural-functionalism (Radcliffe-Brown); structuralism (Lévi-Strauss); culture and personality (Benedict, Mead, Linton, Kardiner and Cora-du-Bois); neo-evolutionism (Childe, White, Steward, Sahlins and Service); cultural materialism (Harris); symbolic and interpretive theories (Turner, Schneider and Geertz); cognitive theories (Tyler, Conklin); post-modernism and post-structuralism.

1.3.5 Culture, Language and Communication

• Nature, origin and characteristics of language; verbal and non-verbal communication; social context of language use.

1.4.1 Research Methods

• Fieldwork tradition in anthropology; distinguishing features of anthropological fieldwork; survey research.

1.4.2 Human Genetics

• Methods and application of human genetics; methods of studying genetic principles in a population; Mendelian genetics; concept of heritability; population genetics and Hardy-Weinberg law; genetic polymorphism and selection; linkage and crossing over; mutation, migration, genetic drift; factors affecting equilibrium; chromosome and chromosomal aberrations; recombination, genetic load, genetic effect of radiation.

1.4.3 Human Growth and Development

• Pre-natal growth, birth and post-natal growth; factors affecting growth; ageing and senescence.

1.4.4 Human Variation and Adaptation

• Concepts and measures of human variation: racial, ethnic and population; biological and cultural factors in human adaptation; human adaptation to environmental stresses; acclimatization; ecological rules; human adaptability and biocultural adaptations.

1.4.5 Theories of Evolution

• Theories of organic evolution (pre-Darwinian, Darwinian and post-Darwinian); synthetic theory; molecular and modern trends in evolutionary biology.

1.4.6 Primatology

• Principles of primate behaviour; social behaviour of non-human primates; primate evolution.

1.4.7 Phylogenetic Status, Characteristics and Distribution of Prehistoric Man

• Phylogenetic status, characteristics and distribution of prehistoric man.

1.5.1 Theories of Culture and Cultural Change

• Concept and theories of culture; culture change and acculturation.

1.5.2 Culture, Ecology and Adaptation

• Culture as adaptive mechanism; ecology and culture; ecological anthropology.

1.5.3 Epidemiological Anthropology

• Bio-cultural dimensions of disease; health, disease and culture.

1.5.4 Applications of Anthropology

• Applications of anthropology in designing of educational, social and economic programmes; contribution of anthropology to the understanding of regionalism, communalism and ethnic and political movements.

Reference: UPSC Civil Services (Main) Examination syllabus. Verify against the latest official UPSC notification for any amendments.